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AN EITHER/OR QUESTION

The BJD faces a near-existential dilemma in taking on the BJP in the state



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TO DO OR NOT TO DO? BJD president Naveen Patnaik

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

THE BIJU JANATA DAL (BJD), which lorded over Odisha for over two decades, finds itself in a bind. Looming in front of it are two near-existential choices: whether to support or move a no-confidence motion against the BJP-led state government, and which side to back in the upcoming vice-presidential election. Both decisions could inflect the BJD's political destiny. Its old stance of equidistance from both the Congress and the BJP had value and strategic sense in the past. Would it be wise to tread the same line now? Or would it be the deepest folly, exposing it to allegations of opportunism or, worse, irrelevance?

The immediate pressure comes from the Congress, led by new state president Bhakta Charan Das, who has aggressively taken on both the BJD and the BJP over rising crimes against women. Following the shocking self-immolation of a girl student in Balasore and other high-profile incidents of gender-based violence, Das has urged the BJD to move a no-confidence motion in the upcoming assembly session against the Mohan Majhi-led BJP government. The Congress has just 14 MLAs in the 147-member House, so it's daring the BJD, which holds 51 seats, to play the lead—it would offer full support. Das frames it as a matter of moral urgency, invoking the Supreme Court's criticism over the incidents.

WHICH SIDE ARE YOU ON?

Das's 'offer' has created a strategic dilemma for the BJD. If it moves or backs a motion, it risks being painted as an ally of the Congress, a party it displaced and has historically opposed in Odisha. Resisting could reinforce the perception that the BJD acts as a "friendly Opposition" to the BJP, a charge it often incurs for its selective support to the Centre on key bills, most recently the controversial Waqf Bill.

Senior BJD leaders like Debi Prasad Mishra and Arun Sahoo have maintained a guardedly elusive, non-committal stance. "No official notification has been issued yet," says Mishra, stating a final decision would be taken by the legislative party once the assembly session is formally announced. Sahoo accuses the BJP of dragging its feet on convening the session itself, claiming "negative public opinion is the real no-confidence motion".

The BJP has responded with a mix of bravado and provocation. State chief